

1778–1789

FRENCH A LA MODE

Towards the end of the 18th century people of fashion looked to France for the latest word on matters of taste in clothing, manners, and cultural trends. But on the eve of the Revolution, the French aristocracy were out of touch with the general population, and it showed in the excesses of their dress. The styles of the age included tightly waisted bodices and draped and padded skirts. Upthrust, corseted bosoms were set off with low, round necklines, often edged with lace. Hair tended to be high-rise and hats were big. The French influence, and exquisite textiles such as Lyon silk, ensured that well-bred ladies were not merely dressed in fine clothes but were themselves sophisticated adornments both in society and at home.

1778



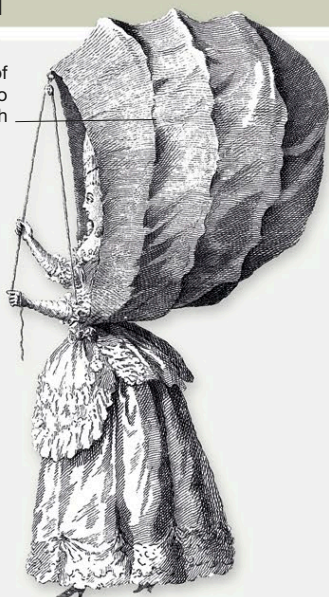
Supporting structure Ladies wore very wide skirts supported by a framework of cloth-covered cane hoops called a “pannier”. Here, with this vital accessory in hand, a dressmaker hurries to her client.



High hats Women favoured big hats with flat brims, tilted to the back or slightly to one side. Underneath this dress is a separate petticoat – the word at this time describing an underskirt that was meant to be seen.

CALASH

Series of hoops to support cloth



Cartoon of calash

To protect their towering hairstyles, women wore a kind of bonnet called a “calash” after the similar hood on a horse-drawn carriage of this name. Usually made of fine silk stretched over hoops made of cane, wood, or whalebone, the calash folded away concertina-style when not in use. No calash was as vast as the caricature seen here, which is taken from a book of illustrations poking fun at 18th-century fashion.

Decoration included feathers, flowers, and ribbons



Crowning glory Hair was complicated: padded, powdered, curled and rolled, and heavily adorned. Dressed hair was left untouched for months, and “scratchers” were used to deal with itches and vermin.

1779



Sack back Sometimes spelled “sacque back”, the term refers to a style of dress with a loose back falling from the shoulders. Generally popular early in the century, by the 1770s the sack back was for court wear only.